

Elaborate hairstyle adorned with feathers

Frills and ruffles Flouncy aprons served no purpose – they were purely for decoration. This impractical fashion was inspired by the French Queen Marie Antoinette, who enjoyed dressing up and pretending she was a milkmaid.

Nosegay pinned to bodice

Bodice over back-fastening corset

Dressed down When a lady was at home, getting ready or receiving visitors, she wore a type of attire referred to as “undress”. Although the style looks fussy and elaborate, the term meant “relatively informal”.

Full, loose sleeves

High hairstyle with side rolls
Muslin fichu (scarf)

Muslin apron decorated with pink bows

Short, flounced petticoat

Soft silk In contrast with the heavy brocades and patterned silks fashionable for gowns in the early 18th century, ladies at this time favoured plainer, light, floaty fabrics known as “slight” silks.

Long, tight sleeves

Puffed back bustle

Matching bracelets on both wrists

Floral headdress and triple-rolled side curls

Jewelled necklace

1789

Flounced silk petticoat

Swagged overskirt

Ruffled hem

High-heeled shoes made of printed leather or silk

Polonaise On some dresses the overskirt could be lifted up and draped in swags, like a pair of curtains – the effect was called a “polonaise”. Although the word suggests Polish origins, the style originated in France.